BONUS III · LET YOUR WORK BE SEEN

Portfolio Photos & Styling Tips

Photographs and styling that show the workmanship



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> *A corset is a piece of structure, texture and careful handwork. Good photographs let all three show. This bonus gives you simple, phone-friendly guidance on photographing and styling your finished pieces, so the shape, the fabric and the workmanship are easy to appreciate when you share them online.*

1. Before You Press the Shutter

You do not need a studio or an expensive camera. A recent phone, a window and a quiet corner are enough to produce images that feel polished and honest. What matters most is light, a calm background and a steady hand.

Before photographing, give the piece a final look. Trim loose threads, press the seams, smooth the lacing and brush off lint. A corset that looks crisp in person will look crisp on screen, and small flaws are magnified in a photograph.

> **The golden rule**
> Photograph the piece the way you would want to see it if you were deciding whether to make one yourself: clear shape, clear seams, clear fabric.

2. Photographing with Your Phone

Natural window light

Soft daylight from a window is the most flattering and most forgiving light you can use. Place the corset beside the window so the light falls across it from the side or slightly in front. Side light reveals the curve of the panels and the texture of the fabric; light straight from behind flattens the piece and turns it into a silhouette.

Avoid direct sun hitting the fabric. It creates hard shadows and glare on satin and shine on boning channels. If the sun is strong, hang a thin white sheet or curtain over the window to soften it.

Choosing the time of day

Mid-morning and mid-afternoon on a bright day usually give even, gentle light. Early morning light can look cool and bluish; late evening light turns warm and dim. Try the same spot at two different times and compare. Once you find the hour that suits your room, stay with it.

Neutral background

A plain wall, a roll of paper or a smooth sheet in white, cream, soft gray or warm beige keeps the eye on the corset. Avoid busy wallpaper, patterned bedding and visible clutter. Contrast helps: a light corset looks best against a mid-tone background, and a dark corset against a lighter one.

Stability, resolution and a clean lens

- Hold the phone with both hands, elbows against your body, or lean it against a stack of books.

- Use a small tripod or phone stand if you have one, and the self-timer to avoid shake when you tap the screen.
- Shoot at your phone's highest standard resolution and avoid heavy digital zoom. Step closer instead.
- Tap the screen on the corset to set focus and exposure, then slide the brightness slightly down if the fabric looks washed out.
- Wipe the lens with a soft, clean cloth before every session. A fingerprint smudge is the most common cause of hazy photos.
- Keep the phone level. Tilted horizons and leaning seams make the shape look distorted.

3. Mannequin, Model or Flat Lay?

Each presentation has its strengths. Many makers use two of the three so a viewer can understand both the shape and the construction.

OPTION	BEST FOR	WATCH OUT FOR
Dress form / mannequin	Showing true shape, seam placement and fit lines; easy to repeat the same shot	Adjust the form to the right size and pad gaps so the fabric does not wrinkle or gape
Live model	Showing movement, how the piece sits on a body and the finished styling	Needs a comfortable, willing person; get written permission; never lace beyond what feels comfortable
Flat lay	Showing pattern, fabric, trims and lacing details from above; no equipment needed	Can make the piece look smaller and flatter; smooth wrinkles and keep the lacing symmetrical

> **Comfort comes first**
>
> If you photograph a corset on a person, lace only as snugly as is comfortable and take breaks. If there is any pain or difficulty breathing, loosen it right away. This is general craft guidance, not medical advice.

4. The Essential Angles

A small set of consistent angles tells the full story of a piece. Photograph each one at the same distance and height whenever possible, so a viewer can compare images easily.

Front

Stand square to the center front, with the camera at about the middle of the corset. Keep the busk or front closure straight and the top and bottom edges parallel to the frame. This is your main image and should be your cleanest.

Three-quarter view

Turn the form or yourself about 45 degrees. This angle shows the curve of the side panels and the way the seams travel around the body. Many people find it the most attractive view of the shape.

Back with lacing

Show the lacing in full. Before shooting, even out the loops, lay the ribbon or cord flat and tie the bow neatly. A tidy back is a quiet sign of care.

Close-ups: seams and fabric

- **Seam detail:** a close shot of two panels meeting, showing straight stitching and an even seam allowance finish.
- **Fabric detail:** a macro-style shot of the weave, brocade, lace or satin sheen, with the light raking across the surface to show texture.
- **Tulle detail:** for sheer panels, place a plain contrasting background behind the tulle so the net and any edge finish are visible.
- **Edge and binding detail:** the top or bottom edge, or the hook-and-eye or busk area, where neat finishing shows.

For close-ups, move the phone nearer rather than zooming in digitally, and tap to focus on the exact spot you want sharp.

5. Props and Styling

Props should whisper, not shout. Their job is to set a mood and give a sense of scale, never to compete with your work. Choose one or two and leave the rest of the frame calm.

- **Backdrop fabrics:** a pressed linen, muslin or velvet drape in a muted tone gives depth. Iron it flat first.
- **Dried flowers:** a small sprig of lavender, baby's breath or pampas grass adds softness. Keep them to one side of the frame.
- **A mirror:** an antique-style or simple framed mirror can show the back view in the same shot. Check that you and the phone are not visible in the reflection.
- **Soft textures:** a wooden surface, a ribbon spool or a few vintage buttons can hint at the craft behind the piece.
- **A hanger or hook:** a plain wooden hanger on a clean wall works well for showing a corset without a form.

> **Avoid clutter**
>
> If you need more than three objects in the frame, remove some. A single tidy element almost always looks better than a crowded scene. Watch the edges of the picture for stray cables, laundry, and cups.

6. Basic Editing

Editing should help the photograph look the way the piece looks in person. It should never change the shape of the garment or the true color of the fabric. The editing tools already built into your phone are all you need.

1. **Crop and straighten.** Make verticals vertical, and crop to a consistent ratio such as 4:5 or 1:1.
2. **Brightness.** Lift slightly if the picture looks dim. Avoid bright, blown-out highlights on satin.
3. **Contrast.** A small increase adds clarity. Too much creates harsh shadows and hides texture.
4. **White balance.** If whites look yellow or blue, adjust warmth until a white or cream fabric looks neutral.
5. **Sharpness.** A light touch helps stitching show. Over-sharpening makes noise and halos.
6. **Compare to the real piece.** Hold the corset next to the screen and check that the color is close.

Go easy on filters. Strong presets can shift reds into oranges, make ivory look gray, and hide the very details you worked so hard on. If you are unsure, choose the less edited version.

7. Visual Consistency Across Your Portfolio

When someone sees several of your pieces together, a consistent look makes your work feel intentional and professional. Consistency does not mean every photo is identical; it means they clearly belong to the same collection.

- Use the same background color or a small family of two or three backgrounds.
- Keep the same crop ratio and a similar distance for each main image.
- Shoot every piece in the same room and, if possible, at the same time of day.
- Apply the same light edits to every image, in the same order.
- Keep the order of images consistent: front, three-quarter, back, then details.
- Choose a simple naming system for files, such as piece-name_front, piece-name_back.

A quick test: place six of your images side by side on your phone screen. If they look like they come from one hand, you are on the right track.

8. The 12-Photo Shot List

Use this list for each finished corset. If a piece only needs a smaller set, take the first eight and add details that make this piece special.

SHOT LIST: 12 PHOTOS PER PIECE

☐ 1. Front view, full piece, straight on

☐ 2. Three-quarter view, left side

☐ 3. Three-quarter view, right side

☐ 4. Back view with the lacing tidy and the bow tied

☐ 5. Side view showing the profile of the panels

☐ 6. Close-up of the front closure or busk area

☐ 7. Close-up of two seams meeting with straight stitching

☐ 8. Close-up of the main fabric texture

☐ 9. Close-up of the tulle, lace or special trim detail

☐ 10. Top edge or binding detail

☐ 11. Flat lay with the pattern, fabric swatch or trims beside it

☐ 12. Styled shot with one or two simple props

9. Writing Captions and Descriptions

Good words make good photographs more useful. A caption gives a quick story; a description gives the facts. Together they help viewers understand what they are seeing and how it was made.

Short captions

Keep captions to one to three sentences. Start with what the viewer sees, then add one detail about making it. For example: *Ivory brocade corset with a front busk and silk ribbon lacing. Hand-finished binding at the top edge.*

Fuller descriptions

For your portfolio pages, include a few clear facts. These help other sewers learn and help any viewer trust your work.

DETAIL	EXAMPLE
Materials	Cotton coutil, silk-blend lining, bamboo-free flat steel boning, cotton lacing cord
Size	Made in Size M, based on the 28 in (71 cm) waist measurement from the pattern table
Pattern	Pattern name or number from the collection
Process	Muslin test made first; two fittings; hand-finished binding
Time	About 18 hours over one week
Notes	Lined with a sheer tulle overlay; lace-up back

> **Be honest, be specific**
>
> Describe what you made and how, without exaggeration. Specific details such as the fabric, the finish and the testing steps are more convincing than big adjectives.

10. Building an Online Portfolio

A portfolio is simply a tidy, easy-to-browse home for your best work. It can be a free website builder page, an online gallery, a simple blog or a well-organized album. Choose the format you will actually keep up to date.

The gallery

- Show your strongest 8 to 15 pieces, not everything you have ever made.
- Lead with your best image and group pieces by style or theme.
- Add the short caption beneath each piece, and link to a larger set of detail photos.
- Use images that load quickly; resize large files before uploading.
- Update it every few months, and retire older work that no longer represents you.

The About page

Write a short, warm introduction. Say who you are, how you started sewing, what you enjoy making and what a visitor can expect to find. Two or three short paragraphs and one friendly photo are plenty. Keep it personal but not private.

Model permissions

If a person appears in your photographs, ask for their permission before publishing. A simple written note works well: it should say where the photos may appear, whether their face may be shown, and how they would like to be credited. Respect their wishes if they later ask you to take an image down. If the model is a minor, check the rules where you live and obtain permission from a parent or guardian.

11. Image Rights and Credits

This section is general information, not legal advice. Rules differ from place to place, so check the rules that apply to you.

- Photographs you take generally belong to you, but you may still need permission from people shown in them.
- If someone else photographs your work, agree in writing how the pictures can be used and how they should be credited.
- Credit your photographer, model, stylist and location as a matter of courtesy, and credit any pattern designer as appropriate.
- Only use music, fonts, backgrounds and graphics you have the right to use.

- Do not use other people's photographs of their work as your own, even as inspiration for a caption.
- Purchasing the collection does not automatically grant resale rights to the digital files. Check the terms that come with your files before selling finished products.

12. Sharing Your Pieces on Social Media

Social platforms are a good place to show your work as it grows. Share the process as well as the result: a muslin test, a seam being pressed, a finished lace-up back. People enjoy seeing the craft behind the piece.

- Post your clearest front or three-quarter image first.
- Add a carousel with the back and detail shots for those who want to look closer.
- Write a caption that describes the materials, the size and one thing you learned.
- Use a handful of relevant tags rather than a long list.
- Respond kindly to questions and comments, and thank anyone who shares their own work.

> **No promises, no inflated prices**
>
> Describe your pieces honestly. Do not promise health, body-shaping or income results, and do not claim a piece will change anyone's figure. If you decide to sell finished work, set a fair price based on your materials and time, state it plainly, and make sure you have checked the file terms first. There is no guarantee of earnings.

13. Common Mistakes to Avoid

MISTAKE	EASY FIX
Photographing in dim, yellow room lighting	Move beside a window and use soft daylight
Busy or cluttered backgrounds	Use a plain wall or a smooth sheet
Wrinkled fabric or untidy lacing	Press, smooth and tie the bow before shooting
Digital zoom that makes images grainy	Move the phone closer instead
Smudged lens	Wipe it with a clean, soft cloth first
Strong filters that change colors	Edit lightly and compare to the real piece
Inconsistent angles and crops	Follow the 12-photo shot list every time
No captions or details	Add materials, size and process in a few clear lines
Publishing a person's photo without asking	Get written permission first
Overstated claims or inflated prices	Keep descriptions factual and prices fair

14. A Simple Session Routine

1. Finish and press the corset; trim threads and tie the lacing neatly.
2. Set up your plain background beside a window.
3. Clean the phone lens.
4. Place the piece on the form, a hanger or a flat surface.
5. Shoot the 12-photo shot list in the same order each time.
6. Review the photos on a larger screen and delete the blurry ones.
7. Edit lightly: crop, brightness, a touch of contrast.
8. Write the caption and description while the details are fresh.
9. Save the files with clear names and keep a backup copy.

Next Step

Choose one finished corset and photograph it with the 12-photo shot list this week. Place the best three images side by side, write a short caption for each, and notice what you would change next time. A little care with light and detail is often all it takes for your work to be seen the way you made it.